

Blurred Vision

By **Christopher J. Brady**, MD, Larner College of Medicine, University of Vermont

Reviewed/Revised Oct 2025

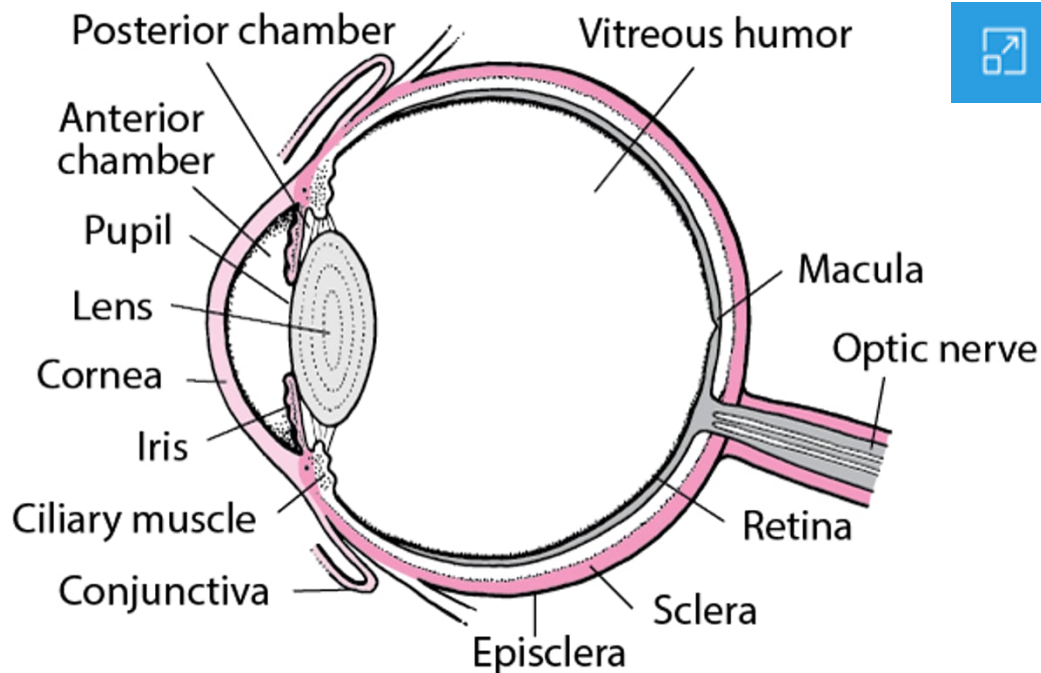
Blurred vision is the most common vision symptom. When doctors talk about blurred vision, they typically mean a decrease in sharpness or clarity that has developed gradually. Sudden, complete loss of vision in one or both eyes (**blindness**) is considered something different.

Causes of Blurred Vision

Blurred vision has 4 general causes:

- Disorders affecting the retina, the light-sensing structure at the back of the eye
- Clouding of normally transparent eye structures (cornea, lens, and vitreous humor—the jellylike substance that fills the eyeball) that light rays must pass through to reach the retina
- Disorders affecting the pathways of nerves that carry visual signals from the eye to the brain (such as the optic nerve)
- Imperfect focusing of light rays on the retina (**refractive errors**)

An Inside Look at the Eye



Certain disorders can have more than one cause. For example, refraction (focusing ability) can be impaired by early [cataracts](#) or by the reversible lens swelling caused by poorly controlled [diabetes](#).

Some disorders that cause blurred vision are more likely to cause other symptoms that prompt people to seek medical attention, such as [eye pain](#) and [eye redness](#) (for example, acute corneal disorders such as abrasions, [ulcers](#), [herpes simplex keratitis](#), or [herpes zoster ophthalmicus](#)).

Common causes

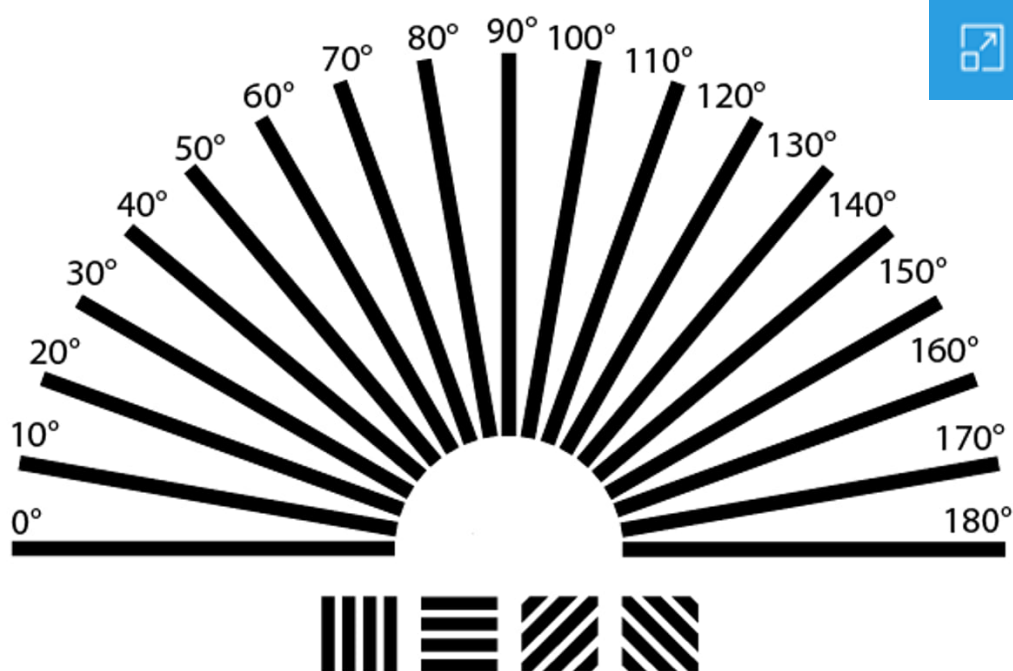
The most common causes of blurred vision include:

- [Refractive errors](#) (such as nearsightedness, farsightedness, or astigmatism), which are the most common cause overall
- [Age-related macular degeneration](#)
- [Cataracts](#)
- Damage of the retina resulting from diabetes ([diabetic retinopathy](#))
- [Glaucoma](#)

What Is Astigmatism?

Astigmatism is an irregularity in the curvature of the cornea or lens. That is, the cornea or lens is curved differently in different directions. This difference causes light traveling in different planes to be focused differently. For example, vertical lines may be in focus when horizontal lines are not (or vice versa). The irregularity can be in any plane, however, and is often different in each eye. A person with astigmatism (each eye should be tested separately) tends to see certain lines more boldly (that is, in better focus) than the others. Astigmatism can be corrected with prescription eyeglasses or contact lenses. It often occurs together with nearsightedness or farsightedness.

The diagram below is of a standard chart used to test for astigmatism in one eye at a time.



Less common causes

Rare disorders that can cause blurred vision include:

- Inherited disorders affecting the optic nerve, called [hereditary optic neuropathies](#) (for example, dominant optic atrophy and Leber hereditary optic neuropathy)
- Corneal scarring due to [vitamin A deficiency](#) (rare in high-income countries)



Some Causes and Features of Blurred Vision

Cause	Common Features*	Diagnostic Approach
Clouding of normally transparent eye structures		
Cataracts	Symptoms that begin gradually Loss of the ability to distinguish between light and dark (loss of contrast) and glare (seeing halos and star bursts around lights) Often in people with risk factors (such as older age or use of steroids [sometimes also known as glucocorticoids or corticosteroids])	A doctor's examination
Corneal scarring after an injury or an infection	Usually in people with a previous injury or infection	A doctor's examination
Disorders that affect the retina		
Age-related macular degeneration	Usually symptoms that begin gradually, but onset may be sudden Loss of central vision (what a person is looking at directly) much more than peripheral vision (what is seen out of the corner of the eye)	A doctor's examination Sometimes, an eye imaging test, such as optical coherence tomography (specialized imaging of the back of the eye) or fluorescein angiography (using a fluorescent dye to



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